

THE EXISTENTIAL POKER GAME

Screenplay by John Hawthorne

Rewritten as a short film script

FADE IN:

EXT. WESTMINSTER / CECIL COURT – DAY

WILLIAM SMITH, a life coach in his fifties, exits a hospital after a routine appointment. He slips an NHS letter into his pocket and walks directly towards camera. From behind, William heads into Cecil Court. The street feels oddly displaced, as if it sits between hospital, Parliament and dream.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

This is William Smith. A life coach. He is doing everything correctly. He exercises regularly and eats healthily. He is on his way home from a routine medical appointment. Today William will do something unusual. He will stop. William stops outside a strange bookshop window.

INT. MARCHPANE BOOKSHOP – DAY

William enters. His eyes rise to a Dalek-style ray gun displayed above him. The gun gleams absurdly in the dusty light.

The SHOPKEEPER appears, wearing a wild Mad Hatter-style hat.

SHOPKEEPER

Hello, sir. Anything in particular you are looking for? I'll tell you what — I've got some more interesting stuff downstairs.

William hesitates, then follows him down.

INT. BOOKSHOP BASEMENT – DAY

A BANKSY-STYLE ALICE materialises in the basement. On a table lies a Lewis Carroll book, faintly pulsating.

ALICE

This is for you, William.

She dematerialises.

William picks up the book. As he climbs back upstairs, the world shifts.

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. WILLIAM'S BACK GARDEN – DAY

William places the Lewis Carroll book on a garden table. He takes out the NHS letter and begins to read.

The words blur: NHS. DEAR MR...

William collapses onto the grass.

The book pulses on the table. Sirens rise beneath the sound of a slowing heartbeat.
FADE TO BLACK.

INT. HOSPITAL WARD – DAY

William jolts awake in a busy hospital ward.

WILLIAM

Oh God, no. Someone get me out of here.

He tries to climb out of bed.

A DOCTOR sweeps in, eccentric, intense, speaking so quickly that William cannot interrupt.

DOCTOR

Hello, William. I have important news. You have a very rare condition: Max Born Heisenberg Syndrome. The quantum entanglement of your brain's neurons no longer matches the structure of your heart. At a subatomic level, the two organs are out of step. If we do not correct this problem, you will die very soon. Within the hour.

William stares, stunned.

An AI NURSE materialises in the ward wearing a Covid mask. As the image resolves, she becomes a REAL NURSE. She removes the mask, smiles and winks at William.

The Doctor offers William a tablet.

DOCTOR

This is very new. Hush-hush. Pre-clinical trial. A temporary fix. It will give you one extra hour of life. But there is a cost. Your mind — or possibly your body — may experience an effect not dissimilar to time travel.

WILLIAM

I demand a second opinion.

The Nurse offers him water.

NURSE

Don't worry. It will be fine. Drink it.

William trusts her. He swallows the tablet.

As he passes out, the Nurse's face fills his vision.

FADE OUT.

EXT. RIVER – ROWING BOAT – DAY

William lies flat in a rowing boat, wearing a hoodie. He wakes to the sound of singing.

FEMALE AI BOT

Row, row, row your boat, gently down the stream, merrily, merrily, merrily, life is but a dream.

William sits up. The Female AI Bot rows with effortless precision.

William checks his phone. Thirty minutes have elapsed.

WILLIAM

Only thirty minutes left.

FEMALE AI BOT

I have analysed your condition and, as a result, you are in this boat.

WILLIAM

What? This is a ridiculous prank. Stop the boat.

FEMALE AI BOT

Do not worry. A full cure is available at the Network on Wey Island. Provided you play their game.

WILLIAM

What game? I'm not playing any game.

FEMALE AI BOT

If you want the cure, you will need to win a round of Medical Poker.
An EXISTENTIAL WATERSPOUT rises from the river.

WATERSPOUT

William, life has no meaning. The universe is random. It doesn't care.
The boat brushes the waterspout. It collapses back into the river.
William lies back down as the Bot rows on. Swans drift past in dreamlike silence.

EXT. WEY ISLAND – UNDER THE FLYOVER – DAY

Futuristic hover cars pass above. Beneath the bridge, William's phone alarm sounds.
A WHITE RABBIT appears on the riverbank, waistcoat and pocket watch in place.

WHITE RABBIT

Oh dear! Oh dear! William will be late!
William jolts fully awake. He jumps from the boat and ties it to a metal peg on the shore.
In the shadows, a SECURITY GUARD emerges, dressed in pre-Raphaelite clothing.
William takes a long walk towards him, like an old gunfighter approaching a duel.
The Guard blocks his path.

SECURITY GUARD

No further, pal. You need to pay the ferryman two hundred ZOTS if you want to get in the game.
William checks his phone. Forty minutes gone. Twenty left.

WILLIAM

Will you buy the boat? It has to be worth two hundred ZOTS.
The Guard eyes the boat, unimpressed — then spots the Bot's laser gun.

SECURITY GUARD

Tell you what, pal. Throw in the gun and the boat, and I'll give you two hundred ZOTS.
William nods.
A black rotating obelisk rises nearby. When it stops, a Victorian door appears in its surface.
William enters the door. The Female AI Bot remains behind.

FEMALE AI BOT

Ask for QuantumSlimVac!

INT. THE NETWORK CASINO – MEDICAL POKER ROOM – DAY

The casino is a surreal den of iniquity: priests, pre-Raphaelites, silver AI bots, toga-clad gamblers, waiters, Greek masks, wizards and gangsters pass behind the poker table.
At the entrance stands the CROUPIER — the same face as the Nurse and the Rower.

CROUPIER

What medication do you require?

WILLIAM

QuantumSlimVac.

The Croupier leads him to a table. Four players wait: the QUEEN OF HEARTS, the MAD HATTER, the PLAYBOY and a GANGSTER. Each carries a laser pistol.

The Croupier places tablets on the table, shuffles and deals.

CROUPIER

Good luck, everyone.

Close on eyes. Sweat. Cards. Ray guns. William's phone.

William looks at his hand: two aces. He bets twenty ZOTS.

The Queen of Hearts smiles at her full house.

QUEEN OF HEARTS

Forty ZOTS.

The others fold. William pays to see her hand. He loses. She takes the money and her drug.

QUEEN OF HEARTS

This is easy.

William's phone alarm BLARES. Everyone jumps and reaches for their guns.

CROUPIER

No hands on ray guns.

They slowly release their weapons. She deals again.

William checks his phone: fifty-three minutes gone.

The Playboy sees four aces and grins.

PLAYBOY

Oh boy.

The Playboy bets fifty ZOTS. William, sweating, matches it. The others fold. The Playboy wins.

William's phone shows fifty-five minutes gone.

CROUPIER

All hands on the table, please.

William hides his phone under the table. It shows fifty-seven minutes gone.

WILLIAM

Sorry.

The next hand is dealt.

The Mad Hatter reveals confidence: a straight flush. He bets one hundred ZOTS.

Everyone folds except William.

William looks at his cards. Time is almost gone.

WILLIAM

I call.

The Mad Hatter smiles and adds ten more ZOTS.

MAD HATTER

To finish you off.

William pushes in the extra ten.

The Mad Hatter lays down his straight flush and reaches for the medication.

WILLIAM

Wait.

William lays down his cards.

A royal flush.

WILLIAM

Royal flush.

The room erupts. The Queen of Hearts, the Mad Hatter and the Gangster shout over one another, accusing William of cheating. Ray guns rise.

William's phone shows 59:55.

In panic, William grabs the medication and stuffs it into his mouth.

The gamblers fire.

William is hit by a barrage of ray-gun blasts as his phone alarm rings.

One hour.

The Croupier stares, shocked.

EXT. WILLIAM'S BACK GARDEN – DAY

William lies on the grass beside the garden table. Alive or dead, it is impossible to tell.

On the table: the Lewis Carroll book and William's royal flush.

Alice appears. She picks up the book and dematerialises.

INT. MARCHPANE BOOKSHOP – DAY

The book rests once more on the basement table.

Upstairs, the Shopkeeper welcomes a new customer exactly as he welcomed William.

FEMALE AI BOT (V.O.)

Row, row, row your boat, gently down the stream, merrily, merrily, merrily, life is but a dream.

FADE OUT.

THE END